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Dare to Share

Teachers' experiences with a participatory design approach to professional development

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Abstract

The aim with this study is to explore how English as a Foreign Language teachers and teachers-to-be experience participating in a collaborative, practice-based professional learning process focused on supporting students' willingness to communicate. Specifically, the study investigates whether and how participation in a participatory design process informed by restorative pedagogy supports teachers in developing new approaches to fostering students' willingness to communicate. The study applies a qualitative action research approach and is built around data in the form of journals, transcripts of a meeting and other collaboratively constructed materials. The project included two teachers and two teachers-to-be who, in accordance with the applied participatory design, shared in creating all of these materials. The findings of the study suggest that being part of a participatory design allowed for a deeper integration of theoretical knowledge into situated practice and compared to previous experiences of professional development activities, participation in this project felt more effortless, natural and educational. The voluntary aspect of the process also gave the participants a sense of agency which was highly beneficial to their willingness and ability to engage and learn. Apart from these findings, several models such as the Dare to Share-model and Participatory Design Circle were constructed during this process that in themselves could be interpreted as valuable contributions to the research field and the participants' local teaching communities.

Keywords: Didactics, Communicative Language Teaching, Thematic Analysis, Participatory Design, Restorative Practices, Willingness to Communicate

List of abbreviations used in the paper

CLT = Communicative Language Teaching
CoP = Communities of Practice
DTS = Dare to Share
EFL = English as a Foreign Language
EPD = Educational Participatory Design
L2 = Second Language Learning
PD = Participatory Design
PLD = Professional Learning and Development
RP = Restorative Practices
WTC = Willingness to Communicate

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Introduction

No amount of formal education can fully prepare a teacher for the realities of the classroom. As soon-to-be English teachers in Swedish lower and upper secondary schools, we found ourselves confronted by one recurring challenge: many students hesitate to speak English in front of their peers, regardless of proficiency. Repeated encounters with this phenomenon, and hearing the frustrations of other teachers, made us question whether our own training had adequately prepared us to support students' communicative engagement.

Our prior experiences suggested a path forward. One of us had participated in a professional development process inspired by participatory design and restorative pedagogy in a U.S. high school, observing dramatic changes in students who had previously avoided speaking in class. Students not only met curricular requirements, but began actively asking for help and supporting one another's learning. The other brought a theoretical background in psychology, informing an understanding of how affective and relational factors, such as psychological safety, can be as influential on students' willingness to speak as personal traits like shyness or anxiety.

Motivated by these experiences, we saw our independent study as an opportunity to explore how teachers might develop context-sensitive, relational practices in EFL classrooms that support students' willingness to communicate. In doing so, we aimed to investigate professional learning processes in which teachers collaboratively engage with research-based knowledge while adapting it to the relational and interactional realities of their classrooms.

With that said, we would like to thank our knowledgeable, creative, generous, flexible, brave and utterly enjoyable colleagues who participated with us in this study and for the gift of knowledge in practice we co-created which we now take with us into our future teaching careers.

Background

In English as a foreign language (EFL) classrooms in Swedish lower and upper secondary schools, spoken interaction is a central component of both instruction and assessment. National curricula emphasise the development of communicative competence through active engagement in communication, placing spoken interaction at the core of language learning. Despite this, research and professional discourse indicate that many EFL teachers experience persistent challenges related to students' reluctance to communicate verbally in the classroom. Reluctance to speak constitutes not only a didactic concern, as limited participation in spoken interaction may restrict students' opportunities to develop language proficiency in line with curricular goals, but also a concern for how teachers develop and adapt teaching practices that are responsive to dynamic, context-specific classroom challenges. It is expected that EFL teachers will create and maintain a classroom environment in which students are both willing and able to use English to communicate. This places a high demand on teachers' ability to design, sustain, and adjust learning environments that support students' willingness and confidence to participate in spoken interaction.

International research in second language learning has increasingly conceptualised students' readiness to engage in spoken communication through the construct of willingness to communicate (WTC), defined as an individual' s readiness to engage in communication in the target language at a given moment with a specific person or people (Ismail et al., 2023). Growth in WTC research over the past two decades has been linked to the widespread adoption of communicative language teaching approaches (CLT), which foreground interaction in meaningful contexts as a primary driver of language learning (MacIntyre et al., 2002). CLT, which underpins contemporary language education in Sweden and internationally, is grounded in sociocultural and socio-constructivist perspectives that view language learning as emerging through meaningful social interaction (Council of Europe, 2020; Jakobsson, 2012; Säljö, 2021). This approach presupposes students' active participation in spoken communication, making reluctance to speak a significant pedagogical concern.

While there is a large body of academic literature investigating individual psychological and affective factors that can impede verbal participation, such as speech anxiety (Inada, 2021), hesitation to speak English in the classroom should not be understood solely as a result of students' individual deficits such as lack of knowledge or lack of confidence. Hesitation should also be considered in terms of the social, relational, and pedagogical conditions in which classroom communication takes place, and how these conditions affect students. Research on WTC shows learners' verbal participation is not only shaped by linguistic knowledge, but also by interpersonal, contextual, and affective factors, including classroom relationships, perceptions of safety and prior experiences (MacIntyre, et al., 2022).

From a classroom perspective, this means that teachers' pedagogical practices (how they structure interaction, respond to students, and establish norms for participation) play an important role in shaping students' readiness to communicate. Understanding how these factors emerge in everyday teaching practices, and how teachers effectively create conditions

that support communicative participation, is therefore a key concern for EFL education (Burgoon, 1976).

While WTC research offers valuable insights into students' communicative behaviour, integrating and adapting this empirical knowledge into classroom practice is not a straightforward process (Gao et al., 2024) and contextual constraints complicate teachers' ability to put academic knowledge into action. Research and professional discourse suggest that EFL teachers in Sweden are generally aware that students' willingness to communicate is influenced by affective, psychological, social, and contextual conditions, yet often lack access to practice-situated knowledge that supports the didactic task of fostering verbal participation in everyday classroom interaction.

Within the Swedish educational context, this pedagogical challenge must be understood in relation to the institutional expectation that teachers' instructional decisions are grounded in both research-based knowledge and tried and tested professional experience. The dual emphasis established by the Swedish Education Act (2010:800) and articulated by the Swedish National Agency for Education (Skolverket) creates the expectation that teachers both engage with research-based insights and integrate their own and others' professional experience into didactic decision-making and lesson design.

Although the requirement that teaching should rest on scientific knowledge and proven experience establishes clear expectations for instructional design, evidence suggests that the conditions under which teachers are expected to fulfil this mandate are questionable. A recent report by the Swedish National Audit Office (Riksrevisionen) identifies structural challenges related to the educational mandate (RiR 2025:31). The report points to inconsistent or limited support from school authorities, as well as a lack of time and resources for teachers to engage systematically with research as part of their everyday work. According to the report, these conditions risk undermining teachers' ability to translate research-based knowledge into high quality, context sensitive teaching practices.

While the report raises concerns regarding teachers' ability to meet the scientific knowledge and proven experience mandate, educational policy has traditionally emphasised collegial learning as a way to help teachers work towards fulfilling it. Collegial learning is commonly described as a collective, reflective engagement with practice in which teachers collaboratively examine instructional challenges, share experiences, and develop professional knowledge grounded in their everyday work. From a research–practice perspective, it could be argued that on-the-job, collaborative inquiry is an essential mechanism through which research based insights are transformed into situated professional knowledge that can be applied across classrooms.

Despite the tradition of collegial learning in Swedish education, however, the audit report notes that the current state of collegial interaction within schools lacks the structural support needed to generate "proven experience" as it is mandated (RiR 2025:31). Taken together, the tension between policy expectations and everyday professional realities, along with the challenges of transforming scientific knowledge into practice, exposes a definitive need for professional learning models that support collaborative, practice-situated didactic inquiry while remaining feasible within existing school contexts.

This need is particularly evident in relation to context-sensitive areas of teaching such as EFL students' willingness to communicate (WTC), which involve relational, interactional,

and affective dimensions of classroom practice. For instructional approaches to be effective in this domain, they must be informed by scientific evidence yet responsive to local classroom conditions. In this regard, traditions of professional development grounded in action research and other practice-situated empirical approaches might provide relevant structural support needed to integrate research-based knowledge and proven experience into professional practice.

Participatory, and action research methodologies conceptualise professional learning as a result of situated, participatory, and dialogic processes (Rönnerman, 2012; Langelotz, 2017). Such approaches not only align with the sociocultural and constructivist assumptions underlying communicative language learning, but they also provide process scaffolding through which teachers and researchers co-construct professional knowledge in and through everyday practice. Within these frameworks teachers are positioned as professionals capable of developing evidence-based practices and exercising contextual judgment in adapting them in situ. Teachers are not considered to be merely disseminators of externally produced knowledge as they are within transmissive models of professional development (Kennedy & Stevenson, 2023).

As research on WTC indicates, supporting students' willingness to communicate is fundamentally a relational pedagogical concern, requiring intentional development of interactional practices that shape classroom relationships, participation norms, and affective safety. Supportive teaching practices identified through research findings cannot be directly implemented in the form of externally produced knowledge. That knowledge must be transformed through reflective, practice-based professional learning to accommodate complex, situational classroom realities. Against this backdrop, it is relevant to examine how EFT teachers engage with research-based knowledge regarding students' WTC and how knowledge exploration, adaptation and development can be scaffolded within the contexts of teachers' every day professional practice.

Drawing on participatory design research methodology, the present study defines professional learning as a process in which teachers collaboratively explore and shape teaching practices in response to their lived classroom realities, not as a simple process of implementing predefined solutions or strategies. Participatory design provides process scaffolding for teachers to explore relevant pedagogical practices through a didactic and interactional framework within their situated EFL teaching contexts. Restorative pedagogy is one such pedagogical approach that incorporates many aspects known to affect students' WTC. Restorative pedagogy (RP) can be described as a relational pedagogical stance that positions relationships, dialogue and mutual concern at the center of teaching and learning. It also aims to foster positive relationships among peers and between students and teachers, while promoting prosocial behaviour through the development of students' social and emotional skills. RP offers a relational framework for structuring classroom communication in ways that promote inclusion, dialogue, and shared responsibility for participation. Restorative practices such as circles, dialogic problem-solving routines, and structured opportunities for verbal expression provide concrete interactional scaffolding through which relationships can develop in the classroom.

In EFL contexts where communicative language learning depends on students' willingness to take interpersonal risks, interactional norms and structures within the

classroom are particularly consequential. Restorative pedagogy and associated practices, can be used to provide a framework for shaping the communicative ecology of the classroom and align closely with research results that emphasises the role of interactional norms, affective safety, and relational trust in enabling verbal participation.

Building on Swedish traditions of collegial learning and practice-situated professional development, the present study investigates how a small group of EFL teachers and teachers-to-be participate in a process of collaborative inquiry informed by participatory design and restorative pedagogy, with the aim of exploring professional development related to students' willingness to communicate in EFL classrooms.

Literature Review

Willingness to Communicate (WTC) in L2 Learning

The concept WTC refers to an individual's readiness to interact verbally with a person (or people) at a given time. Thanks to decades of research applying the WTC model, it is well established that learners' readiness to engage in foreign language communication is influenced by affective, psychological, social, cognitive and contextual factors, many of which are shaped within classroom practice. Stemming from this research are volumes of suggested research-based classroom strategies to support L2 students' WTC.

Considering one of the main goals of teaching English in schools as outlined in the The Swedish National Agency's subject plan for English is to allow students to "develop a trust in their own ability to use the language in different situations and for different purposes" (Skolverket, 2021), knowing how to support students' willingness to participate verbally in class is a crucial skill for English teachers. While the present study explores professional learning processes related to supporting students' willingness to communicate, it is not meant to evaluate the value of the WTC model, nor does it aim to evaluate the effects of EFL teacher practices on student WTC. However, the WTC model plays a central role in the present study as a shared, evidence-based conceptual framework orienting participants to the project's aims, facilitating collaborative sense-making of classroom experiences related to students' reluctance to speak, and establishing a common purpose for the inquiry. A brief overview of the WTC model and existing research on EFL teachers' role in supporting students' willingness to communicate is therefore warranted.

Overview of WTC research in foreign language (L2) learning

Figure 1
Heuristic Model of Variables Influencing WTC

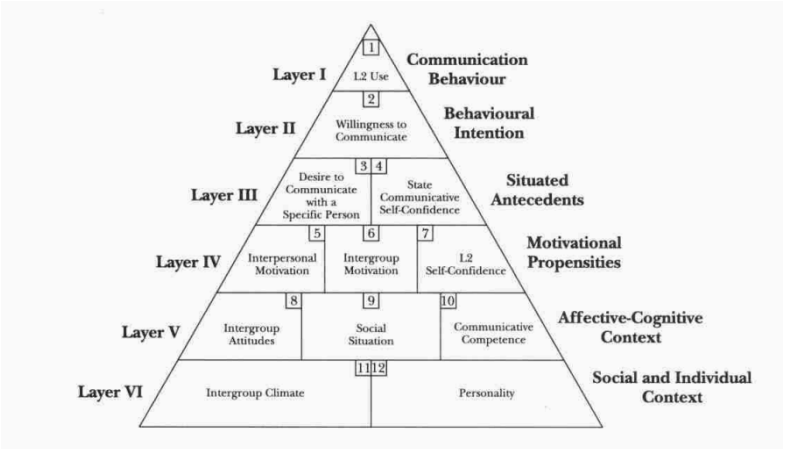


Figure 1 depicts a visual representation of variables that are known to influence willingness to communicate (MacIntyre, P. D., et al. 1998)

The Willingness to Communicate construct, which examines personal and contextual factors that influence speakers' voluntary engagement in communication using L2, is a well-established construct that is widely known within the field of L2 learning research. Within the field, WTC is considered a crucial aspect of L2 learning due to modern language pedagogy's emphasis on active communication (MacIntyre et al., 2002). The existing literature has predominantly focused on learners and psychological variables such as perceived competence, anxiety (Gao et al., 2024), the desire to communicate with a specific person, self-confidence, motivation and personality, often using quantitative and outcome-oriented methodologies (Syed, 2022). However, a recent literature review of studies investigating situational factors affecting WTC identified classroom atmosphere, classmate behaviors, L2 learners' relationship with communicative partners, class size, teacher behaviors, task design and sense of safety as critical for L2 learners WTC (Zhang et al., 2018). The studies included in the review make a compelling case for L2 teachers' need to understand and actively address these situational aspects.

However, less attention has been paid to how L2 teachers go about doing this. There are some recent studies that involve exploration of teacher strategies for addressing classroom-related aspects of WTC that demonstrate the significance of teachers' role in supporting L2 learners. Teacher strategies identified as being important in these studies include: providing emotional support (Wei & Xu, 2021), interactional strategies like asking open-ended questions and responding to students' non-verbal behavior (Peng, 2020), carefully framing feedback (Attia & Algazo, 2025; Hejazi et al., 2023, Nahid et al., 2019), effectively managing group dynamics (Inada, 2021), framing mistakes as essential to learning (Attia & Algazo, 2025), using engaging material and creative tasks (Nahid et al., 2019) and giving students personalized feedback and using collaborative tasks (Gao et al., 2024). However, results from these studies, which are primarily small, qualitative investigations, provide a static snapshot of factors affecting a specific set of students in a given place and time and therefore, conclusions from these studies are difficult to apply directly in situated learning contexts.

What is clear, based on the existing literature of L2 learners' WTC is that translating this body of scientific knowledge into professional practice is an important, but not straightforward or simple process and teachers need to be properly supported if they are to make use of it.

Bridging the research-practice gap

How evidence-based professional knowledge develops has been a central question for scholars of professional learning for decades; and the persistent research-practice gap between L2 learning research and classroom practice is widely acknowledged within language education. Sato and Loewen (2022) argue that sources of the division include the traditional positioning of researchers as sources of expert knowledge, de-contextualization or "intellectualisation" of educational problems and teachers' limited access to resources such as

time and access. The research-practice gap, as it is understood in language learning, mirrors the broader issue which has been widely recognized within research and professional communities for decades.

Donald Schön, a central figure in theories of professional learning, describes the conditions of professionals' work situations as complex, uncertain, and dynamic situations that cannot be fully addressed by pre-existing rules or theories. Challenging existing models of professional work, Schön (1983) argued professional practice is theoretical knowledge-in-action developed by practitioners through real-world action which is context-sensitive and cannot be separated from the situations through which it was developed. Early work by Michael Eraut, a leading scholar in professional learning, aligns with these claims, Eraut (1985) argued professional knowledge should not be seen as a product of directly applying formal, research-based theory, but as knowledge that has been interpreted, adapted, and developed within the conditions of practice.

Within the Swedish educational context, Karin Rönnerman (2012) has further advanced these ideas by demonstrating how collaborative action research can function as a practice-based approach to professional learning, positioning teachers and researchers as co-constructors of knowledge grounded in everyday school practice. Together, these perspectives frame professional learning as a situated, reflective and collaborative process, offering a methodological orientation for understanding how teachers engage with, adapt, and implement research-based knowledge within their professional practice.

The collaborative, practice-based research agenda outlined by Rönnerman is reflected in a growing body of empirical studies examining how teachers' engagement in action research and related collaborative inquiry models can support professional learning, self-efficacy, and the development of context-sensitive pedagogical practices (provided that appropriate scaffolding structures are in place). Rather than viewing research as something produced *for* teachers, participatory and action research is produced *with* teachers in which real-world classroom concerns are at the center of inquiry. This fundamental shift towards a collaborative mindset in which researchers and practitioners work together and contribute equally toward the shared goal of student learning is, according to the authors, a key to closing the research-practice gap, but only if it is properly supported by institutional scaffolding that enables sustained dialogue and cooperation (Sato and Loewen, 2022).

Collegial learning and professional development in Swedish education

Action research and other related practice-situated approaches that foreground democratic dialogue, participation, and site-based praxis development align with the Swedish tradition of professional development known as collegial learning. In Sweden, collegial learning is commonly conceptualised as a form of professional development grounded in collective, reflective inquiry into practice, where teachers collaboratively generate professional knowledge through dialogue and shared problem-solving (Rönnerman, 2012; Langelotz, 2017). As with the perspectives on professional development developed by Schön, Eraut and Rönnerman, collegial learning does not position teachers as recipients of externally produced knowledge, but as the source of locally relevant, professional knowledge. The collegial

learning tradition emphasises professional agency, contextual relevance, and sustained engagement with everyday educational practice.

From this perspective, effective professional growth does not emerge primarily through attending courses or workshops, but through ongoing collaboration, reflection, and experimentation in practice that allows teachers to construct knowledge in action and refine instructional strategies over time (Rönnerman, 2012; Löfström & Areskoug, 2020). Professional knowledge developed through iterative cycles of reflection, action, and collective sense-making is thus viewed as being context situated and relational (Rönnerman & Salo, 2017; Edwards-Groves et al., 2021). In Sweden, this approach to professional development has been institutionally legitimised in education through initiatives supporting practice-situated research and long-term collaboration between schools and universities (Langelotz & Olin, 2022).

Practice-situated and collaborative forms of professional development are not the only model being applied within the Swedish educational system, however. Discourse in recent decades regarding appropriate forms of professional learning and development (PLD) in education reveal a dichotomy of existing models referred to as either transmissive or transformative. In this regard, transmissive models see teachers' as disseminators of externally produced knowledge and prioritise standardization and compliance over contextual sensitivity and teacher agency. Transformative models, on the other hand, see teachers as experts on the contextual conditions of their practice who are capable of critical reflection and are active producers of knowledge. These models tend to emphasise collective inquiry and the importance of professional agency in PLD (Kennedy & Stevenson, 2023).

In response to recent policy developments in Sweden, there has been a renewed discussion about the balance between standardised professional development initiatives and long-standing Swedish traditions that emphasise collegial learning, reflective practice, and learning in and for practice. Scholars have raised concerns regarding a recently developed initiative intended to support professional development that promotes a centrally governed, standards-based model of competence development. They argue that such top-down approaches risk prioritising predetermined content and compliance over context-sensitive professional learning grounded in teachers' everyday practice (Francisco, Forssten Seiser & Olin Almqvist, 2024). Taken together, these tensions between transmissive and transformative models of professional learning, alongside policy pressures toward standardisation, raise important questions about how professional knowledge can be developed in ways that remain responsive to the situated, relational, and interactional nature of classroom practice.

Educational action research in language learning

Questions regarding appropriate professional development models are particularly important in language education, where learning is not only a cognitive process but emerges through social interaction, participation, and communicative risk-taking. Contextual factors that can limit students' ability to engage in communicative language learning require constant professional responsiveness from L2 teachers that cannot be mastered through absorption of

academic literature alone. As such, research approaches that enable teachers to systematically inquire into their own instructional practices in collaboration with others, have gained traction within language education research, providing another channel for professional development. Educational action research and associated methods have emerged as a means for bridging research-based knowledge and everyday professional practice in language classrooms.

For example, Wyatt and Dikilitaş's (2015) study examining how English language teachers at a Turkish university developed professional self-efficacy through sustained engagement in action research denotes a shift in L2 research toward learner-centered, context sensitive approaches. The results show how teachers' sustained engagement with research can be transformative when it is properly scaffolded. Although the participating teachers initially experienced uncertainty and low confidence in conducting classroom research, sustained participation in collaborative inquiry, mentoring, and regular collegial meetings supported their gradual development as practitioner-researchers. Over time, participants became more learner-centred, critically reflective, and flexible in their pedagogical decision-making, demonstrating how research engagement can foster knowledge in practice.

Similar results were reported by De Neve et al. (2015), whose action research study in secondary education demonstrates how teacher-led inquiry can support the development of formative assessment practices in L2 teaching. Their findings suggest that when teachers collaboratively investigate their own classroom practices, professional learning becomes more sustained, context-responsive, and pedagogically meaningful than externally imposed professional development initiatives. Baengas et al. (2017) provide additional evidence of the transformative potential of participatory and collaborative action research approaches to professional development of EFL teachers. Their collaborative investigation of their teaching practices illustrates how professional learning emerges through collective reflection, classroom observation, and collective decision-making in the teaching context. Transformative, professional development occurred over time through iterative reflection and shared responsibility rather than through application of predefined practices. While they acknowledge that collaborative action research is time-consuming and requires sustained effort, they argue this is an inherent condition of democratic, context-responsive professional learning that should not be compromised.

Closely related to the present study, prior research in EFL teacher education suggests that collaborative action research is most effective when it is supported by collective scaffolding, sustained dialogue, and democratic participation structures which illustrates how participatory inquiry can support professional learning. (Ceylan and Comoglu, 2023). Owing to their engagement in the research process, the pre-service ELF teachers experienced a significant shift in their view of research as a remote academic activity to an invaluable yet manageable part of teachers' professional practice development. The experience imbibed participants with a sense of confidence in conducting research and in their future professional role. Their reported reconceptualization of themselves as active decision-makers and problem solvers and future agents of change in the educational context was attributed to the inquiry process. Importantly, the study highlights how democratic and collaborative research environments, characterised by symmetrical power relations and mutual support fosters

transformative professional learning. These results in particular, influenced the use of a participatory design approach in the present study.

Educational Participatory Design - an emerging field

Participatory design (PD) is a process approach originating in the tradition of Scandinavian software development within the field of human-computer interaction (Cumbo & Selwyn, 2022). Participatory design, which involves multiple participants' collaborative inquiry of common problems and development of possible solutions through reflection in action supported by a process of mutual learning. It is intended to engage individuals in the production of alternative solutions or resources (which include professional practices) to address challenges encountered in work or everyday life. This is contrasted to solutions that are proposed by actors having managerial or expert authority (such as researchers or administrators) who lack situated experiential authority (Bødker et al., 2022). Similar to action research, participatory design assumes practitioners, in this case teachers, are capable actors who contribute valuable contextual knowledge to the development of professional resources and practices that are sensitive to contextual complexities of the communities they engage in.

Until very recently, PD has been applied primarily within the field of child-computer-interaction and computing education (Cumbo & Selwyn, 2020), but recently there has been a recent surge in interest for PD methods within educational research. PD is an approach intended to support mutual learning through equitable partnerships between experts and professionals. Through collaborative sense-making, localized problems are addressed through cooperatively designed and contextually relevant solutions, artifacts or practices. Not only does PD harmonize well with sociocultural and constructivist perspectives underlying modern language pedagogy, it also speaks to aspects of design thinking that have found their way into educational discourse as with lesson design, for example (Wallberg, 2019). For these reasons, PD appears to be perfectly positioned to bring teachers and researchers together in sustained collaboration for pedagogical development (Musaeus et al., 2024).

While participatory design has not yet been applied as a method of action in willingness to communicate research specifically, it has been used as an exploratory and transformative approach within language teacher education and professional development. In a seminal study, Kinnula et al. (2023) introduce educational participatory design (EPD), conceptualised as a collaborative process in which participants engage in hands-on design activities, structured reflection, and joint sense-making aimed at transforming situated professional practices. As with other forms of educational action research, EPD foregrounds mutual learning, equalisation of power relations, and the positioning of teachers as designers of their own work practices. Importantly, this study shows how it is possible to integrate design work with practice development in education, enabling teachers to envision novel practices while simultaneously developing a sense of agency through meaningful participation in the design process.

As L2 willingness to communicate is currently understood to be a situated, context-dependent construct which is shaped by social and interactional aspects such as social

relations, classroom interactional norms, and learners' experiences of participation and safety, it cannot be meaningfully studied or developed through decontextualized interventions alone. To that end, participatory design is particularly well suited to the study of WTC because it treats classroom practices, interactional patterns, and professional assumptions as objects for collaborative design. It also positions teachers as partners in the exploration of social and relational conditions that shape learners' readiness to engage in communication.

From this perspective, PD provides the necessary process scaffolding through which relational pedagogical approaches that foreground dialogue and shared responsibility can be explored, interpreted, and adapted to classroom communication practices. Rather than prescribing strategies for increasing willingness to communicate, PD enables teachers to collectively examine how communicative willingness is produced, constrained, or supported within their own professional contexts, and to design responses that are locally meaningful, relationally grounded and contextually feasible.

Relational pedagogy and restorative practices

In recent decades, schools internationally have increasingly adopted relational pedagogies such as restorative justice. These approaches are often positioned as alternatives to behavior management strategies centred on individual students and punitive measures such as sanctions, strict rule enforcement, and exclusionary practices like detention or suspension. Such strategies are commonly used in response to issues like bullying, exclusion, intolerance, discriminatory language, and other behaviours that violate a school's expressed values. Research suggests that these approaches frequently have limited effects because they overlook the relational and contextual factors underlying conflict, safety concerns, and harmful peer dynamics (Vaandering, 2014; Lodi et al., 2021). Practices described as restorative in educational contexts draw on Indigenous ways of knowing and community-based approaches to conflict resolution, responsibility, and relationship-building. Over time, these practices have been reconceptualised beyond their origins in restorative justice programmes and are now understood as part of a broader pedagogical orientation (Lodi et al., 2021).

Within education, restorative pedagogy has come to denote a relational approach to teaching and learning that emphasises relationship development, dialogue, inclusion, and shared responsibility as foundational conditions for learning (Hollweck et al., 2019). Rather than focusing primarily on rule enforcement or behavioural correction, restorative pedagogy promotes the cultivation of classroom communities in which students experience belonging, voice, and mutual respect. Learning is understood to be a fundamentally social process in which relationships are not a secondary priority to instruction but as central to students' participation, risk-taking, and sense of safety in the classroom.

One of the most widely used restorative practices in educational settings is the use of "community-building circles" or "restorative circles", which provide structured opportunities for dialogue, listening, and shared meaning-making (Joseph-McCatty & Hnilica, 2023). Circles are designed to flatten traditional hierarchies, distribute voice more equitably, and collectively establish interactional norms that support respectful communication and

collective responsibility. Research suggests that these practices can contribute to strengthened relationships, increased student participation, and a more inclusive classroom climate, though their impact is highly dependent on contextual implementation and sustained pedagogical commitment (Lodi et al., 2021). Despite the growing interest, research reveals that school-wide restorative initiatives are often difficult to implement and sustain, particularly when introduced as mandatory behavior modification programs rather than as practice-situated pedagogical orientations (Lodi et al., 2021).

The close theoretical alignment between communicative language learning, collaborative participatory research methods, and restorative relational pedagogy offers a strong rationale for using participatory design to introduce restorative principles in ways that support context-sensitive, didactic adaptation to local conditions and instructional aims. Against this backdrop, the present study explores the potential of combining participatory design with restorative pedagogical principles as a practice-based approach to professional learning. By engaging EFL teachers and teachers-to-be in collaborative inquiry informed by restorative values of dialogue, inclusion, and relational responsibility, the present study investigates how restorative pedagogy may function as an interactional framework for developing teaching practices intended to support students' willingness to communicate through improved social and relational classroom conditions.

Theoretical starting point

In this section, an overview of three theoretical frameworks that support the analytical and action methods used in this study are presented. First, however, it is necessary to mention the ontological assumptions underlying the choice of analytical approach for this study. One aspect that distinguishes participatory and action approaches from other methodologies applied in educational research is the role of the researchers. While educational researchers are typically, to varying degrees, detached from the contexts they investigate, in this case researchers are practitioners *and* participants. While this is typical for action research and participatory design processes (Bødker et al., 2022; Löfström & Areskoug, 2020) researcher objectivity cannot be established in the same way as it is in positivist traditions.

From a relativist (non-positivist), qualitative perspective, objective knowledge can never be achieved as there is no one single truth or reality waiting to be discovered. The aim of qualitative analysis is to discern meaning, which emerges through relational interaction within a specific context and can therefore fluctuate depending on the situation (Braun & Clarke, 2022). Rather than striving for objectivity, the researchers in this study attempt to present a transparent account of the subjective, situated meanings collaboratively generated by the participants through cycles of design activity, situated action and co-reflection with the help of several theoretical frameworks.

Sociocultural theory provides a theoretical foundation for the qualitative analysis method chosen to help answer the present study's research questions. Together with situated learning theory and reflective practice, these theories also provide context for the use of participatory design and restorative practices as appropriate scaffolding for the experimental, collaborative inquiry approach used to explore EFL teacher's development of knowledge in practice regarding students' willingness to communicate.

Sociocultural theory

Sociocultural theory aligns well with the ontological assumptions mentioned previously. From a sociocultural perspective, reality is primarily experienced by humans through a process mediated by language and interactive communication with the surrounding environment. Human cognition, which includes thinking and learning, is understood to be shaped by the use of cultural artifacts in social interaction with other individuals. From this perspective, language is the most important cultural artifact influencing how individuals perceive their surroundings and experiences. Reality, as it is experienced by a specific individual at any given time is therefore inherently subjective. There is no observable objective reality. However, intersubjectivity, which is the emergence of shared understanding between individuals, can be achieved through mutual engagement (Jakobsson, 2012; Säljö, 2021).

Likewise, sociocultural theory assumes that knowledge does not exist as an objective entity outside individuals or solely within them, but emerges through collective activity, dialogue, and shared reflection (Wertsch, 1998). From this perspective, learning and

meaning-making are understood as socially mediated processes. This ontological and epistemological position underpins the analytical approach of the present study, which focuses on how participants constructed understanding through interaction during iterative cycles of design activity, action, and co-reflection. The collaborative sense-making that occurred during process implementation is therefore analysed not as individual cognition, but as collectively negotiated meaning emerging through dialogue and shared practice.

The data, which are treated as textual and interactional representations of these processes, are analysed as evidence of participants' evolving understandings. In line with sociocultural theory, interpretation is understood as situated and mediated rather than neutral or detached. Accordingly, the researchers' own participation in the design process is recognised as part of the meaning-making context rather than a source of bias to be eliminated. The aim of the analytical approach is thus not to avoid interpretive influence, but to make transparent how researchers' experiences and positioning shaped the processes of analysis and interpretation.

Situated Learning Theory: Communities of Practice

Whilst sociocultural theory argues that knowledge is inherently a social construct, situated learning theory specifies the process of knowledge acquisition. This perspective contradicts cognitively oriented models that assume learning entails internalization of socially constructed knowledge into an individual's existing cognitive apparatus. Knowledge is understood to be not only socially constructed, but necessarily embedded within social groups mutually engaged in action, within a specific context, for a common purpose. Learning takes place through active participation in the situated context where said knowledge is in practice. Situated contexts where social groups use and develop knowledge in action are referred to as communities of practice (CoP) (Lave, 1991; Säljö, 2021). Schools are seen as typical examples of situated CoP where professional understanding develops through participation in everyday school activities and cannot be acquired through formal education alone. Common routines, language, norms, and tools develop as teachers and other professionals engage in daily activities with students and staff. According to situated learning theory, this daily engagement (referred to generally as "participation") is central to practice development within a professional community.

In the present study, the participating teachers can be understood as forming a temporary community of practice in which professional knowledge was developed through joint engagement in design activities, classroom experimentation, and collective reflection. The workshops and iterative cycles of action created a situated context where pedagogical understanding emerged through participation rather than through the transmission of predefined knowledge. From this perspective, the study examines professional learning as something that develops within shared practice, mediated through dialogue, tools, and collaborative activity.

Reflective practice theory

Donald Schön, a central figure in theories of professional learning, describes the conditions of professionals' work situations as complex, uncertain, and dynamic situations that cannot be fully addressed by pre-existing rules or theories. Reflective practice theory builds on the assumptions of both sociocultural and situated learning perspectives, claiming that professional practice is theoretical knowledge in action developed by practitioners through real-world action and subsequent reflection on the action. Here, reflection involves critically examining one's actions, the assumptions underlying them, and their outcomes in order to inform future practice.

Reflective practice, as it was first conceptualized by Schön (1983), challenges assumptions that the professional knowledge teachers draw on while teaching is the act of applying eternally produced theory to practice. Schön argues that the work of educational professionals requires a kind of knowledge that can only be developed through engagement with real-world situations coupled with "reflection-in-action" and "reflection-on-action" which help practitioners examine and refine their practice during and after actively applying them in the situated context of teaching.

More recent academic development of the reflective practice concept in educational contexts describes it as a process of examining experiences, learning from outcomes, and planning future action (Machost & Stains, 2023). Research has demonstrated that reflective practices can support professional development and instructional improvement (Dervent, 2015; Zahid & Khanam, 2019), while also identifying structural and contextual factors that may hinder their systematic adoption (Davis, 2003; Sturtevant & Wheeler, 2019). Within teaching, reflection has been described as a means of navigating the dynamic and evolving nature of classroom environments while remaining balanced amid changing students, curricula, and institutional demands (Brookfield, 2017).

Reflective practice is also known to support teacher agency by enabling educators to identify and address potentially exclusionary practices and to respond more effectively to student diversity (Henderson et al., 2011). Reflective practice is said to be strengthened through dialogue and feedback from colleagues and students, by broadening practitioners' perspectives and fostering trust in educational relationships (Brookfield, 2017). Farrell (2012) describes reflection as a compass guiding teachers' professional development, while Löfström and Areskoug (2020) emphasise reflection as the process through which teachers articulate a personal theory-in-use, bridging theoretical knowledge and everyday classroom practice. From this perspective, reflective practice is a key component in the transformation of research-based knowledge into professional action.

Participatory, practice-based, collaborative teacher learning

The triad of theories presented in this section support the choice of action method used to answer the research questions presented in the purpose and thesis section, and they encompass three central assumptions about learning processes assumed in the present study:

- Academic forms of knowledge can be transformed into knowledge in action through participation in collective action in the situated context where the knowledge is in practice.
- Collaborative processes scaffolding that allows practitioners to share experiences and engage in collective, critical exploration of applied practice effectively supports professional learning.
- Participatory processes can be used to bridge the practice–research divide between research activity and professional practice.

Based on these assumptions, we envisioned that an educational participatory design approach informed by restorative pedagogy would provide useful scaffolding and an appropriate mediational medium to facilitate an experimental, practice-based, participatory action process, involving collaborative teacher learning intended to inform teaching practices to support students' WTC.

Situated Learning Theory and Reflective Practice Theory Traditions in Swedish Education

Situated learning theory and reflective practice theory share an understanding of learning as socially situated, practice-based and developed through participation in meaningful activities. Both traditions emphasise that professional knowledge emerges through engagement with real-world contexts, dialogue with others and systematic reflection on experience rather than through the passive transmission of externally produced knowledge. From a theoretical perspective, collegial learning in the Swedish educational context can be understood as an institutionalised practice that reflects key assumptions of situated learning and reflective practice, positioning teachers as active participants in the joint construction and adaptation of professional knowledge. This helps align the theoretical framework of the present study with the aims and challenges present in the real-world context of formal education in Sweden.

Purpose and thesis

The aim of this study is to investigate how EFL teachers experience and make use of a participatory design process informed by restorative relational perspectives to collaboratively develop professional understanding and teaching practices related to students' willingness to communicate.
To guide the investigation of this thesis, these three research questions will be used:

- How do the subjects experience participating in a participatory design process focused on relational and communicative challenges in EFL teaching?
- In what ways do the subjects perceive their participation in the process as valuable for their professional learning and teaching practice?
- How did participation in the process shape the teachers' professional understanding of, and approaches to, students' willingness to communicate in EFL classrooms?

Method

This section presents the methods used to conduct this study and is structured into six parts (most of which contain subsections): participants, process planning, process implementation, application, data collection and analysis, and questions regarding ethics, credibility, transparency and limitations. This study was an exploratory case study using qualitative methods to investigate how participatory design processes informed by restorative pedagogy can facilitate mutual learning in ways to support students WTC through strengthening social and relational conditions with and among students. The PD process in this study was inspired by the educational participatory design approach established by Kinnula, Iivari, Kuure and Molin-Juustila (2023). A design group consisting of two student-teachers, who are also the authors of this study, and two ELF teachers were brought together over the course of five weeks to engage in a collaborative process exploring ways to understand, adapt and apply theoretical concepts including MacIntyre et al.'s (1998) willingness to communicate model, Kinnula et al.'s (2023) educational participatory design approach and various representations of restorative pedagogical approaches to relationship engagement.

Participants

Participants were selected using convenience sampling, or purposive sampling (Bryman, 2016), meaning that the participants were selected based on their proximity to the researchers and suitability for the project. Leading up to the project, the researchers looked for ELF practitioners who were actively teaching English and who felt they had the interest and time needed to participate in the study.

Eventually this study came to involve four different participants. Firstly, the two student-teachers who are the authors of the present study, which both have English as our primary subject. During our school placement experiences we were lucky enough to encounter teachers that were willing to help with this project. We had both been at the same school during all three of our school placement experiences and had had a chance to build relationships with some of the teachers and students. Two of the teachers we had encountered came to be the other two participants involved in this study and together we created two separate pairs, one located in a gymnasium in Stockholm and the other at a high school in Östersund. The teaching experience in the group varied between one year part time and fourteen years full time.

To provide participants as much anonymity as possible, they will henceforth be referred to as T1, T2, T3 and T4.

Process planning

The following subsection outlines the preparations done prior to the participatory design process implementation. An adapted version of Kinnula et al.'s (2023) *Participatory design*

guiding principles were used to design a preliminary implementation plan and to gather mediating materials and tools to facilitate the PD process.

The adapted guiding principles used in the present study

Equalizing power relations - Those who are invisible or in a weaker position in the power structures should also be given a voice

Situated action - the project is contextually relevant, meaning that each application is embedded and is designed to suit local characteristics and circumstances

Mutual learning - Participants of the PD process are encouraged to understand each other, and this is enhanced 'by finding common ground and ways of working'

Tools and techniques that support the actors and the work - The aim of the tools and techniques used within PD is to 'support collective 'reflection-in-action' to enable participants to participate in design'

Infrastructuring (scaffolding) - configuration of the situation, the need for tools and methods and the constant 'becoming' state of the infrastructure

Democratic practices - PD can be seen as a set of values where the idea of democracy 'leads to considerations for proper and legitimate user participation

Genuine participation - fundamental adjustment of the participant's role from being merely informants to being legitimate and acknowledged participants in the design process

Materials gathered or developed

The following materials were created, collected or prepared and made available to all participants prior to the PD process implementation.

Infrastructuring (scaffolding)

Figure 2
Participatory Design Circle

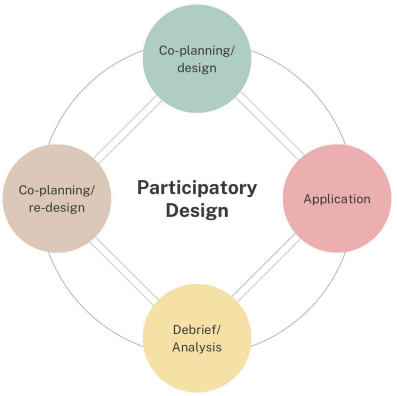


Figure 2 depicts the process model developed to help guide an initial orientation to the PD process which we believed would allow us to fulfil many of the guiding PD principles by providing a flexible yet structured design, while leaving many procedural details open for collaborative decision-making during the implementation phase. The circular model depicts four phases of the collaborative participatory design process as non-linear and iterative:

- **Co-planning/design** - participants co-planned and/or designed an approach or teaching material
- **Application** - designs were tested in participants' situated teaching practice
- **Debrief/analysis** - experiences from application were analysed and reflected upon separately through journaling and/or together with other participants
- **Co-planning/re-design** - if and when the previous analysis suggested it (and time allowed it) a new design was constructed to be re-applied to the situated practice

True to the iterative nature of PD, steps were not necessarily taken in sequential order. Often, several steps took place simultaneously by different participants at different times.

Tools and techniques that support participants and the work

During the pre-process planning phase, a reflective journal template was developed (see appendix 3) to support participants' individual sense-making throughout the project and to support data collection. Initially, journaling was envisioned as a continuous and shared feature of participation. However, as the research process increasingly took on a participatory design orientation, requiring the use of a standardized journal was found to be misaligned with the study's emphasis on autonomy and democratic participation. The journal template was therefore reframed as optional scaffolding rather than a requirement. Participants were free to use the template, adapt it, or engage in reflection through other forms of writing or documentation that they found more meaningful to their own processes.

Owing to the fact that participants were based in two different locations in Sweden, participation in the project was primarily digital. Therefore digital platform Zoom was used for video conferencing and a communally administered webspace called Milanote was used

to create a sense of shared space and to further facilitate communication. The digital webspace provided a low cost, flexible and easy to use digital repository for multiple forms of digital media which could be added to or changed by all group members. Interactive, digital information "boards" which support a wide range of digital multimedia were created in the webspace and made accessible to all participants. In addition to a structure of boards to be used by the group, each member was also provided a board of their own in which they could collect or create materials they found important to their own process, such as their journals. All spaces were however accessible to all participants.

During process implementation, the form of the webspace evolved and was used in a variety of different ways including collaborative mind-mapping of theoretical concepts and as a visual support tool during face to face and video communication. Using various features of the webspace, the group were able to co-create and adapt visual and textual scaffolding to meet their needs as they evolved over the course of the project.

Process implementation

The following subsection overviews the PD process as it emerged over the course of five weeks, addresses considerations regarding the guiding principles of participatory design and accounts for the four phases of the participatory design circle.

Genuine participation and Democratic practices

Staying true to the principles of PD, precise details regarding how the process would unfold once set in motion were not determined prior to the orientation workshop. Decisions regarding which materials participants engaged with and how, what activities or materials the participants designed and applied in their teaching and what kinds of resources were produced emerged dialogically through participant interaction over the course of the implementation phase. Once process implementation began, all participants were considered design team members, having equal authority and value (participants are therefore referred to as design group members in the implementation section). Over the course of implementation, design team members shaped their own role and their contributions to the process based on prior experiences, areas of interest and contextual constraints/opportunities. Even though everyone limited their engagement with the process to the extent they were able and willing to, the whole group attended the initial orientation and final reflection activity.

Initial orientation workshop

An initial orientation workshop was facilitated using a restorative circle–inspired structure. The workshop provided the design group with an opportunity to become acquainted, engage in initial sense-making around the theoretical concepts of willingness to communicate (WTC), participatory design (PD), and restorative pedagogy (RP), share prior experiences of teaching English as a foreign language and students' verbal participation, and establish a shared understanding of the project's aims.

Rather than requiring participants to engage with predetermined readings or formal instructional sessions, the design of the study prioritised engagement with participants' ongoing teaching practices. This reflects a participatory design orientation in which professional learning is understood to emerge through collaborative inquiry, dialogue, and iterative experimentation in situ, rather than through the prior transmission of abstract knowledge (Bødker et al., 2022). Supporting materials related to PD, RP, and WTC were instead made available on Milanote, allowing participants to decide independently which resources to engage with, and how and when to use them.

This design choice is consistent with findings from practice-based collaborative teacher learning research, which suggest that prescribed engagement with published literature may have limited value under contextual constraints such as teachers' limited time (Kiely & Davis, 2010).

Co-planning and design

After the initial orientation workshop, group members signaled a need for more robust scaffolding detailing what was expected of them. In response to the need for more detailed scaffolding, several resources were collaboratively created by the design group in Milanote. An example of one of these resources, referred to by the design team as the "menu", defined different forms of legitimate participation:

- **Explore and reflect** on the Restorative Practice and Participatory Design materials and our collective reflections in Milanote, at your own pace, asynchronously, to the extent that suits you.
- **Explore and reflect** together with all or some members of the team
- **Participate in co-design** activities together with team members
- **Design** activities, give and get feedback asynchronously through Milanote
- **Pilot** activities of your choice with your students
- **Participate in Debrief/analysis** sessions with team members
- **Participate in Debrief/analysis** asynchronously through Milanote

(Text from the participation "menu" in Milanote)

The design group agreed that participation in the project could include all actions, none, or some of them. Whatever level of commitment the group members could commit to at any given moment was considered good enough, as long as there was some communication regarding decisions on participation. A visual reminder was created in Milanote reading, "A 'yes' today could be a 'no' tomorrow, and tomorrow's 'no' could be next week's 'yes'". This reinforced the agreement that even if a member agreed to participate in one way and then found themselves unable to deliver, they could always opt out, or modify their commitment and vice versa. After the negotiation process of co-defining acceptable participation an updated visual overview of the process was also created to support the mutual understanding of how the process would be in constant movement:

Figure 3
Preliminary dare to share process sketch

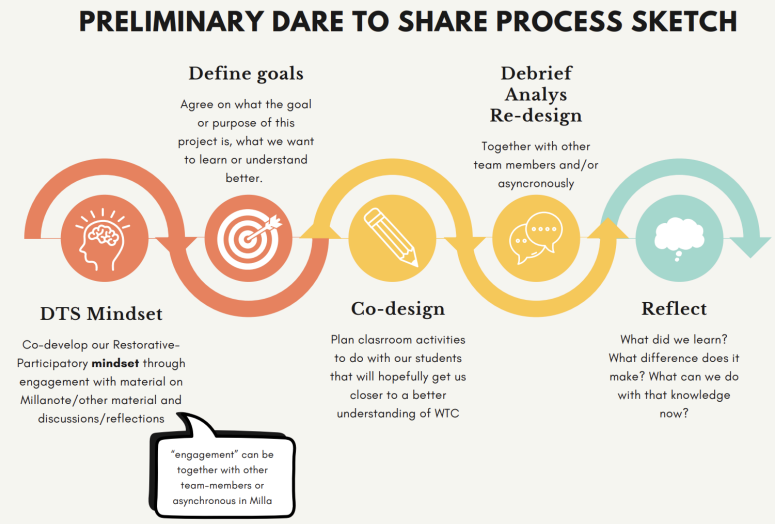


Figure 3 depicts a visual representation of the emerging scaffolding co-created by the participants

During early sense-making/co-design sessions, all members at one point watched a TED talk by Michelle Stowe on "Empathy: the heart of difficult conversations" and reflected with other group members on its meaning and potential application. The video discusses the importance of empathy in relationship development and suggests six restorative questions that can be used to encourage open, honest dialogue, guided by genuine curiosity, supported by mutual concern and respect which can result in mutual learning and strengthened relationships. This approach, as Stowe (2017) points out, is relevant "in the classroom, in the boardroom, in the livingroom, wherever there's people and relationships". The six questions are:

- What happened?
- What were you thinking at the time?
- What have you thought about it since? (what are you thinking now?)
- Who has been affected and in what way?
- How could things have been done differently?
- What do you think needs to happen next?

The TED talk provided a mutual frame of reference to start from in the group's collective exploration of restorative practices which lead to ideas of how to adapt and apply a similar approach with students which were successively put into practice, collectively evaluated and refined by different design team members and different stages of the process.

Application, debrief/analysis and co-planning/redesign

This section outlines how the approaches, activities, and materials co-developed during the participatory design process were applied in classroom contexts, and how these applications were subsequently reflected upon, analysed, and iteratively redesigned. The specific classroom activities described below are presented as separate sub-subsections.

After several iterations of collective sense-making and co-planning, participants began applying different approaches and materials in their classrooms in varied ways and to differing extents. The flexibility of the design process allowed teachers to engage without needing to depart substantially from existing lesson plans; activities were integrated into ongoing teaching to varying degrees. For example, T2 did not have the time to undertake major classroom implementations but contributed actively to group analysis and redesign discussions and participated in classroom activities led by T1. Similarly, while T4 had limited time and space to adapt their existing teaching plans, participation in group discussions enabled them to identify opportunities to apply restorative approaches within their regular lessons.

Throughout the implementation phase, these classroom applications were interspersed with structured reflection. Participants documented experiences through reflective journals and engaged in collaborative sense-making with other group members, which informed ongoing analysis and subsequent redesign cycles.

Restorative circle-informed book club activity

T3 implemented a multi-week English unit focused on students reading a novel while introducing two methods of narrative analysis involving plot structure and internal/external conflicts. The unit included short lectures and smaller assignments designed to support students' understanding of these analytical concepts. In addition to these, a book club component was incorporated to provide opportunities for students to revisit and discuss lecture content while applying it directly to the text. T3 adapted the book club to incorporate restorative circle features with the intention of encouraging student communication.

At first, T3 did not observe a significant change in verbal communication and retrospectively attributed this to a rigid reading schedule and book club questions structured around questions pertaining only to sections of the text outlined in the schedule. Recognizing the need for adjustment, T3 worked collaboratively with T4 to evaluate, re-design the activity and implement a new format. The re-designed approach centered listening as the focus of the activity while T3 posed carefully considered follow-up questions with the intent to keep conversation going. Different designs worked differently with different groups, but overall, T3 perceived an increase in students' willingness to participate verbally in the activity after the re-design. Towards the end of the unit, T3 also observed that students were able to reference the book club discussions in relevant ways during presentations which T3 interpreted as an indication of the activity's success and usefulness.

Restorative approach to confronting students suspected of cheating

On several occasions during the participatory design process, members of the design group encountered situations which required them to address students' potentially inappropriate use of AI for assignment completion. While this topic did not necessarily fall within the design group's initial area of concern, they understood that potential relational consequences of how these interactions were handled could impact feelings of trust and safety in their classrooms. While the teachers all recognized the need to communicate behavioral expectations in these situations, they also recognized the opportunity to adopt a more restorative approach in their communication.

One such situation emerged during student book presentations, where suspected use of AI prompted a series of restorative interventions by T4. Drawing on prior experience, T4 initially approached these conversations in a non-confrontational manner, posing open questions intended to understand students' decision-making. However, during collaborative observation, T3 noted that although the questions themselves were restorative in intent, T4 often did not permit students sufficient space to respond, instead filling the silence with their own interpretations.

This observation became the basis for a group debrief and reflection session, after which T4 intentionally re-designed their approach by slowing the interaction, resting in silence after questions, and drawing more explicitly on established restorative questions such as those suggested by Stowe. Subsequent applications of this re-designed approach were observed and collectively reflected upon by T3, T4 and T1. While T4 described the revised interaction style as more challenging, particularly given the sensitivity of the topic, they also experienced it as more effective in supporting relational alignment. Through this iterative cycle of enactment, observation, reflection, and redesign, T4 reported a clearer sense of how restorative communication practices could shift the tone and relational quality of difficult conversations with students.

The design groups' collective understanding of this restorative approach was further defined and refined when T1 and T2 encountered a similar situation with several students leading to an opportunity to apply the approach which they observed to be a valuable approach for behavior management and relational development with students.

Restorative circle informed activities

Not only were restorative and community building circle-informed activities applied in some of the classrooms, but many of the group's collaborative design/reflection sessions were facilitated using a restorative circle structure. Having experiences with PD and RP facilitation in an educational prior to the present study, T1 assumed the role of facilitator during collaborative co-planning, debrief/analysis and re-design activities. T1 also applied several forms of restorative and community building circle-informed activities with students.

During several weeks of the implementation phase, T2 was preoccupied with administering the national test with their students, which created an opportunity for T1 to act as a substitute teacher and apply a version of community building circles which provided the design group an opportunity to experience the approach first hand or through collective

debrief and analysis. The activities were presented to students as an optional classroom activity. T1 observed enthusiastic attitudes toward the proposed activities as all student groups' collaboratively decided to participate in the proposed activities. T2 was able to participate during some of the activities and also co-facilitated some of them. Circle activities were offered as a classroom activity on several occasions which provided the opportunity to jointly reflect and refine the community building circle approach used by T1 and T2.

Final reflection focus group

The collaborative participatory design process concluded with a focus group activity facilitated by T1 using a restorative framework and questions inspired by the research questions used to guide the present study which provided the design group one final opportunity to discuss and reflect on their experiences participating in the project. The session was recorded and transcribed.

Data and analysis

Methods for collecting data and processing

Data collected for analysis in the current study comprise reflective journal entries written by the design group, digital materials created by the design group and a transcribed recording of the final reflection focus group session. After the implementation phase had finished, textual and visual data produced by the design group were collected (materials produced or collected prior to the process implementation phase were excluded). Collected media forms included, text documents, written comments, lists and reminders, visual representations of concepts and representations of theoretical models. Textual data collected from these sources included notes taken during discussions between some and all of the participants, meeting notes, journal entries, notes made in the communal space in Milanote and the transcription of the audiorecording of last meeting. All meetings (except for the spontaneous ones held between the participants at the same school) were held in English, using Zoom.

Analysis of the empirical material

The transcription of the last debriefing meeting, content collected in Milanote and journal entries made by the participants were analyzed using thematic analysis (Bryman, 2016). According to Bryman (2016), when using the qualitative method of thematic analysis a theme is seldom "expressed in a concrete way" but is more likely to be found in "a category [...] identified by the researcher", in a theme that "is connected to the focus of the research (and most likely to the research questions)" or in "codes that are identified through field notes".

According to Bryman (2016), the thematic analysis process ought to have eight steps which, in this research process, were followed carefully, albeit not necessarily executed in the same order. Firstly, all of the material was read through followed by an initial process of coding. At this time relevant excerpts were color coded in correlation with the research

questions. Thus excerpts expressing participants' experiences of participating, value words (good or bad) connected to the teachers participation and new approaches to managing students' WTC were identified and coded. The third step, suggested by Bryman (2016), was to compile codes under themes. These themes were carefully looked over, to see if any connecting components could be found. Themes with connecting components were grouped together to create an overarching theme. In the end, the original themes created four overarching themes that are the ones used in the analysis section.

When it came to analysing the collected data the researchers chose to take into account both the long-distance collaborative processes and the environment. The ethnographical field notes that constitute the basis for this data were hence compiled in the manner that felt the most conducive to the process, namely in several shared digital documents. Themes produced through analysis were presented to the other participants to ensure a consensus on the connections and conclusions made.

Questions regarding ethics, credibility, transparency and limitations

Reliability and validity are criteria traditionally associated with quantitative research, intended to assess the stability and accuracy of findings. As qualitative research rests on different epistemological assumptions, the applicability of these criteria has been widely debated. Bryman (2016) instead proposes alternative quality criteria for qualitative research: credibility, transferability, dependability, and confirmability; which can be seen as comparable to aspects of internal validity, external validity, reliability and objectivity (respectively).

Credibility in the present study was supported through methodological triangulation, including reflective journals, focus group transcripts, and shared notes in Milanote. This allowed for comparison across data sources and contributed to identifying both convergences and divergences in participants' perspectives. As qualitative research prioritises depth over breadth, statistical generalisation is not the primary goal. Transferability, rather, concerns the extent to which findings may be applicable in similar contexts. Following Geertz's (1973) notion of "thick description," efforts were made to provide contextualised and detailed accounts of the study context and processes, thereby supporting transferability, although the level of detail is acknowledged to be limited. Dependability was enhanced through supervisory audit of the research process and subsequent reflective discussions. Finally, confirmability was addressed through researcher reflexivity and an explicit effort to ensure that interpretations were grounded in the data rather than shaped by personal values, in line with Bryman's (2016) criteria.

During this research, guidelines for good research practice formed by The Swedish Research Council's (Vetenskapsrådet, 2024) were followed. These guidelines are closely aligned with the guiding principles of participatory design used in the present study. Specifically, participation was explicitly voluntary and conditional to participants' needs, desires, values, and obligations. Information regarding the process was made available to and co-adapted by the participants. All data collected was accessible to all participants and data processing procedures were made as transparent as possible which was particularly important

due to the size of the present study making complete anonymization impossible. During the initial meeting participants were introduced to the consent form which was signed by all participants.

Within the situated contexts of the present study, the researchers had previously established relationships with some teachers and students, a circumstance that may be interpreted as both a strength and a limitation. On the one hand, pre-existing relationships provided a foundation of trust that may have supported participants' willingness to engage in experimentation and open dialogue. On the other hand, such familiarity raises questions regarding the genuine voluntariness of participation and the potential for social desirability effects. There is also a risk of interviewer bias, whereby participants may have framed their responses in ways perceived as supportive of the research aims, as well as selection bias stemming from the researchers' recruitment of participants with similar pedagogical orientations (Padgett, 2008).

This potential bias was reflected in a comment made during the final debriefing session, in which one participant noted that the restorative approaches explored in the study closely resembled their existing practice and may not have resonated in the same way with students of different ages or educational contexts. This observation underscores the contextual specificity of the findings and reinforces the need for cautious interpretation.

It is important to note that as the present study was situated in the context of the participants' teaching environments, students were present in this context. However, they were not considered participants in the study and no data directly pertaining to students were collected. Any references to students are based on the participating teachers' reflections or their own pedagogical designs.

Findings

In this section, the emergent themes are presented. Participants' reflective journals, artifacts created in Milanote, and the recorded session revealed three major themes which are each presented in the following sections. One of these themes also includes a sub-theme. A pedagogical model collaboratively designed by the participants called the Dare to Share (DTS) model is also presented.

The participation process allowed for deeper transformation of theoretical knowledge into situated knowledge in practice

Findings from the reflective journals, artifacts created in Milanote, and the recorded session showed that engagement in the project led to deeper integration of theoretical knowledge into situated practice. While all participants signaled that restorative pedagogy, as it was understood by the group, was not unfamiliar, three participants expressed early on in the project that they considered their current teaching practices to be very similar to RP. While they all agreed during the final session that participation in the project had led to a much deeper understanding of what RP are and had either developed or identified new RP-inspired practices they would like to start or continue using in the future.

One of the most detailed illustrations of this emerged dialogically in the final recorded session in which T4 recognized that they would not have meaningfully changed their interaction style during conversations with students if it had not been for the collaborative debriefs with T3. Up until that point, T4 viewed their professional practice prior to the project as being closely in line with restorative approaches and only slight adjustments or minimal learning had occurred. However, questions posed by other participants about T4s experiences led to a reconceptualization about the significance of what they had learned. T4 explained that "a significant part of what has led to more of an exploration and development of [their] style of approaching the students was benefited by [...] T3's reflections and noticing and reflecting back" and recognized that they had done something different from before. These observations align with situated learning theory and reflective practice theory which assumes learning occurs through interactive engagement in meaningful activities and subsequent reflection or sense-making. This example illustrates professional knowledge emerging through engagement with real-world contexts, dialogue with others and systematic reflection on experience.

Sub-theme: Cooperation and co-reflection made participation more valuable

A sub theme that emerged during the final session and researchers' final reflective journals was the recognition that co-reflection during co-planning/(re)design, debrief/analysis phases made participation more valuable because not only did learning happen while applying new activities or materials in the classroom, but everyone learned from each other's experimentations during co-reflection. Additionally, feedback from the other participants caused deeper and more meaningful reflections on the experiences. Conversely, the act of

giving feedback made others' experiences more personally relevant by actively engaging everyone in each others' learning process, which in turn led to new insights for the one who was giving the feedback. A recognition that participating in this process of mutual learning parallelled in many ways what the students go through every day was expressed and also considered to contribute to the list of valuable insights generated during this project.

Compared with previous experiences of professional development activities, participation in the DTS process felt more effortless, natural and educational than expected

Early on in this process, hesitance expressed by participants prior to the implementation phase were twofold. Partially, reluctance was based on participants' concerns relating to prior experiences with professional development initiatives which were experienced as time and energy consuming, detracted from other important obligations related to their teaching, and which resulted in minimal practice development or increased knowledge in action. After being introduced to the mediating materials made available through Milanote, participants were uncertain about what was expected of them. Some were concerned they would be expected to first engage with all of the material and then create specific opportunities outside their previously planned lessons to apply the contents of the material, which was perceived to be asking too much of their limited time and available resources. While these participants felt eager to participate they did not want to take on more than they felt they could handle, which signaled a need for more detailed scaffolding that would allow them to partake in the sense-making process without feeling like they had committed too much.

During the final session, a dialogic reflection on these initial feelings contrasting with how it felt during and at the end of the project emerged. One of the participants explained how their experiences with participating in professional development activities have historically been connected to feelings of pointlessness, compulsion and stress. Even though their pre-process introduction to this research project had been a positive one, those feelings were still present at the beginning of the implementation phase. This description of earlier experiences with and feelings towards professional development emerged as a sentiment felt, to some extent, by all the participants. Despite the researchers' efforts to emphasise their intention to avoid a top-down steered process structure and that participation was a fully voluntary process created by and for the participants, reluctance was still being expressed at the beginning of the implementation phase.

Reflecting on previous experiences with professional development, T4 recognized in the final session that during previous professional development activities in which participation felt like an obligation and during which teachers were expected to perform in a certain way, they did not go into the learning situation with a particularly positive attitude which negatively impacted the outcome. This sentiment of the reflection was shared by several other participants, adding that while they all recognized that the attitude they brought to the occasion was in their control, it was very difficult to feel positive when they also felt like it was taking away critical resources that would have otherwise been put toward their students.

It was not until mid-process implementation that participants began recognizing the extent to which they were all making valuable contributions to the process even though each was encouraged to participate on their own terms and to the extent that they felt was meaningful and possible for them in the moment. Participants recognized during the final session that once they realized they were not expected to "perform" in any predetermined way, continuous participation felt effortless and enjoyable and learning became a valuable side effect of the practice rather than the expressed goal. A collective commitment to the phrase "focus on the process, not on results" which emerged during implementation reinforced the mutual understanding of what it means to participate within the context of this project.

Despite initial concerns regarding the investment of time in the project, frequent interaction between participants was considered helpful to the engagement in the process and contributed to a sense of meaningfulness and joy felt during the project. Opposed to the previous experiences with professional development shared by participants, when several weeks, sometimes months would pass between learning occasions, the frequency of interaction through weekly collective meetings, informal dyadic discussions, or through Milanote or other digitally mediated channels seemed to benefit learning while allowing participants to stay within their own boundaries of reasonable commitment to the project.

The approach of intentionally not putting the emphasis on initial reading requirements, but on trying things out directly in real teaching situations, was not only appreciated by the participants who saw this as one of this approach's greatest strengths, it also supports Schön's (1983) claims that engagement with the real world is necessary for integration of theory into practice. The participants also expressed feelings of surprise that participating did not require more conscious effort, but that it just seemed to happen naturally.

> Yes, my return on investment in this case has been awesome because I don't feel like it has taken too much of my time but at the same time I've received a lot when it comes to finding different tools and approaches to deal with my students and my teaching (T4's reflections during final session)

Participants elaborated on how other experiences have required a lot from them in terms of time and effort whilst being part of a process like this, made it feel like positive things were 'just happening' without an extra effort beyond what is normally required of teaching classes.

> Yeah I feel completely the same, that sort of I haven't um, consciously having to put effort into it then having you here and doing it, it sort of just happens naturally in the process, um, the sort of reflections. And, that's a bit what I mean with the other things we have to do, it's like, now you have to sit down and do this for two hours. Then you feel like you're putting in a lot of effort but you're not getting that much out of it. But if it's included in a dynamic process in a way then you feel like, I'm not actually working for it, it's just happening (T2's reflections during final session)

When the participants talked about their experiences, they expressed how beneficial they felt it was to not be forced into listening to lectures or reading a lot of material that

someone else had deemed beneficial for their development as teachers, but to instead be allowed to decide for themselves what they would want to develop, how and when. These results are in alignment with those of De Neve et al. (2015) and Baengas et al. (2017) which showed that when teachers were given the opportunity to collaboratively investigate their own classroom practices through collective reflection, classroom observation, and collective decision-making, professional learning became more pedagogically meaningful than externally imposed professional development initiatives. These results also reflect the main assumptions of situated learning theory and reflective practice theory that learning is socially situated, practice-based and is developed through participation in meaningful activities.

Agency and voluntariness as conditions that support engagement and learning

Participants recognized that the ability to choose their own area of focus and experimental approach made engagement easier. Because they felt like participation was an option, not an obligation, less barriers to engagement were felt compared to previous professional development experiences. An example of this was the emergent way in which participants collectively negotiated what would count as participation. That negotiation evolved over the course of implementation and included the creation of resources shared on Milanote detailing different options, informal discussions between participants and other mediating artifacts such as the "today's yes could be tomorrow's no" phrase. The result was that participants chose methods of participation that were well suited to their needs, interests and abilities. Participants also noted that the structure of the project encouraged the creation of content that they themselves felt would be beneficial to their learning as teachers and to their students.

> So I, like you said, T2, knowing that I always had the option to say, I'm out, good luck, has been great because you said from the very beginning that, OK, that is a result in itself. Yeah. This whole process. So that has helped greatly. And even though sometimes I felt like, oh, I should have journaled a bit. And we journaled together yesterday (gesturing to T3), for the first time. It hasn't been like, yeah, like I've been forced to do anything. So I haven't put that much effort in if I'm being honest, or not consciously at least uh but I feel that, that I've received a lot in return even though I, I haven't this haven't been at the top of my mind every day when I came to work (T4's reflections during final session)

A general observation was shared, that the more agency to effect the situation students were given the more enthusiastically they participated. Contrary to what participants initially expected of students' readiness to participate verbally in such exercise, a general willingness and at times even expressed preference to communicating in this way was observed among students, despite the fact that participation meant speaking in turn while peers and teachers listened.

Participants observed during collaborative reflections with students that the combination of giving students agency to influence the way things were to proceed combined with collaboratively negotiating agreements on what was considered by teachers and students

to be acceptable participation were important factors that made participation feel fun, safe and valuable.

> The things that I learned from holding these circles, which I also approached very much from a, let's share the power, let go of control over the situation, and really truly give the students a choice in how they want to participate and to what extent. And I learned that I feel like you can't go too far in that direction. So far, at least that's been my experience, that, like, the more you let go and the more you frame things as a choice, the more willing people are to participate (T1's reflections during final session)

T1's reflections on what they learned were echoed by other participants who did not hold circles but observed similar effects in conversations with students when students were given more room to influence the conversation.

> It's the classic teacher thing, right? With asking a question and expecting a specific answer. Like, I have the answer to the question I'm asking. Well, that's not always the case is it, so sort of letting go of the steering wheel and just saying that okay you can lead us in this and that's basically what we're doing right, that's what we're all talking about like letting the groups or circles decide on their own rules and that sort of thing so yeah, I learned how to trust the students more, I guess (T4's reflections during final session)

Reflecting sentiments previously expressed by participants regarding the ease of participation, there was also a general sense of surprise at the amount of novel material and practices that were developed during the short time of implementation. Participants also expressed gratitude for the value the new material and practices brought to their teaching. "I am changed" was a sentiment shared by one participant both verbally with other participants and in reflective journals.

In reflecting on the value of the design of the current project, it was noted that once it was established that participants were given a lot of freedom to choose how to engage, T4 was able to pick something out that allowed them to experiment immediately, without having to make any significant changes to their existing teaching plan. This resulted in an optimal situation for reflective learning to take place. T4 observed, "we already had these presentations going on, it was a good way of starting, natural cyclical nature to it, try things out and then, after feedback got the possibility to do it again". T4's process of iteratively experimenting, participating in collective analysis and re-design was observed by T1 to have made a significant contribution to the development of their knowledge of how to apply restorative practices in difficult situations with students.

Before the end of the project T1 experienced a significant shift in their approach to supporting students suspected of violating local rules of conduct which they directly attributed to direct involvement in T4's learning process. T1 shared how the experience resulted in a boost in confidence in their ability to address difficult situations with students while at the same time strengthening relationships as a direct result of this project. This

example of mutual learning is the core aim of collaborative processes designed to involve practitioners sharing experiences through collective scaffolding, making critical exploration of professional practice possible and effectively supporting professional learning.

T3 reflected on their process of successively choosing to adapt the original form of an assignment they had decided upon prior to this project in favor of allowing students more influence over the structure of the assignment. Initially, they had concerns that the adaptation might compromise the end results and they pondered whether the assignment would contribute to students' development in the way that they had hoped for. What T3 observed during this process was that letting go of control did not compromise the learning experience. T3 observed that by allowing students to adapt the assignment, students began showing signs that they were learning in the way they found most beneficial which felt encouraging.

The DTS model

Much like every other part of this process, the DTS model got its name from lengthy collaborative reflection between the four participants. Fairly early in the process the hesitance around trusting that decisions to share authority would lead to acceptable outcomes vanished and was replaced by a shared feeling of astonishment. We quickly came to realize that this new way of daring to share authority in the classroom, and daring to share one's feelings about it with the other participants, was the most impactful asset of this entire approach. It is from this realization that the name for the paper, and the model it produced, stems.

The DTS model of restorative teacher-student relationships that was collaboratively developed by the participants represents their deepened understanding of how restorative pedagogy can be used to create safe and supportive classroom relationships and their collective shift in approach to encouraging students' willingness to participate by giving students more control over how participation happens. The participants of this study believe these practices contribute to students' readiness to communicate verbally in EFL classrooms.

Figure 4
Dare to Share Model

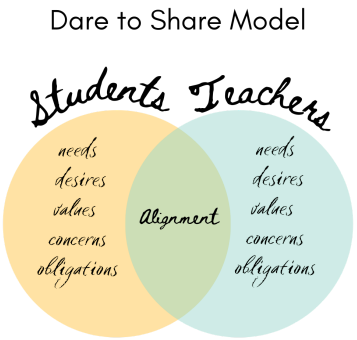


Figure 4 depicts a visual representation of the separate needs, desires, values, concerns and obligations of teachers and students and also how each party must be willing to openly approach the other for the sought after alignment to emerge.

> Mutual learning happens in the alignment space through a collaborative engagement dialogue
> - In instances where teachers perceive students' behavior to be misaligned with their own (the schools, or the aims or values of education in general) the teacher (who is in a position of authority) in an attempt to restore alignment can, armed with restorative questions, lead a collaborative inquiry with the student to explore students' needs, desires, values, concerns and perceived obligations in the moment to identify potential areas of overlap with their own needs, desires, values, concerns and perceived obligations in the moment. Armed with new knowledge about the current situation generated through restorative conversations, students and teachers can collaboratively create a plan of action for restoring alignment and addressing any potential harm caused by the misalignment. (Text accompanying the DTS model in Milanote)

The DTS model designed by the participants represents the shared interpretation of what is being "restored" through restorative practices. For the participants of the study, an emergent relational goal with their students was "alignment", which describes the status of sharing common and identifiable *needs*, *desires*, *values*, *concerns* and *obligations* such as both teacher and student feeling willing to interact verbally in class. Often, teachers and students are "in alignment". Students are understood to behave in accordance with what is expected of them when their internal constellation of needs, desires, values, concerns and obligations make it possible to align with a teacher's expectations. Misalignment happens when a student's perceived needs, desires, values, concerns and obligations cause the student to behave in a way that violates teacher expectations. According to the approach developed by the participants, represented in the model, the teacher has an opportunity and an obligation to address misalignment by learning what factors caused the misalignment using restorative dialogue with the student.

This new framing emerged from collective reflections when participants talked about reoccurring experiences confronting students who were suspected of using AI inappropriately and their observations of what went well and what did not. Because participants were in agreement that alignment can only ever be reached if both parties are open to communicating honestly and listening empathetically, the goal of these confrontations was not to punish the student, but to create conditions for mutual learning about the process that lead to misalignment. With a better understanding of one another, the teacher and student could then agree on a plan to address any harm caused by the misalignment.

This model and the approach it represents illustrates participants'reconceptualization of undesirable or inappropriate student behaviors. Recurring phrasing used by participants during the study to describe previous experiences with addressing student behavior is "a punitive approach". This was used to refer to disciplinary moves in which teachers use their position of authority to explicitly or implicitly administer punishment or the threat of

punishment, with an intent to modify student behavior. This phrasing is commonly used to describe traditional school disciplinary approaches from a restorative pedagogical perspective. Participants used the terms punitive approach and restorative approach when discussing relationships with students in general, making it clear that all teacher-student interactions could be seen as more restorative, or more punitive in character. Often, during collaborative reflection participants discussed ways they had or could be more restorative with students.

Participants considered the materials and approaches designed and refined during the study to have resulted in greater student-teacher alignment when applied in their classrooms. This model, which represents the relational alignment that we as human beings (students and teachers in this case) constantly strive for, also represents valuable contributions this study has made to participants' professional knowledge in action of how to support students' willingness to communicate through designing and applying materials and approaches that improved social and relational conditions in their classrooms.

Discussion

In this section findings from the analysis are put into the context of prior research and other considerations that fall within the aim of the present study. Considering the two-pronged line of inquiry guiding this study which includes the exploration of pedagogical practices that affect contextual factors that shape students WTC and of teachers' professional development, it would be appropriate to discuss the results in two parts relating to those aspects respectively. However, results that emerged from the data largely applied to both how teachers learned during the process and to the practices they identified as beneficial to student learning.

Distributed authority and negotiated participation

Distributed authority and democratic participation are central commitments in both participatory design (PD) and restorative pedagogy (RP) traditions. Therefore, it is no surprise that participants consistently described a shift away from traditional, hierarchical forms of authority towards more distributed and negotiated forms of decision-making. Decisions that are typically made unilaterally by teachers within education or by researchers in academia, such as which questions to pursue, how activities are structured, and what counts as meaningful participation, were instead developed collaboratively through dialogue. This redistribution of authority was experienced as central to both the relational dynamics of the design group and to teachers' emergent interactions with students in the classroom.

Participants reported that trusting students with shared authority over communicative situations played an important role in supporting students' willingness to communicate. By allowing students to co-develop task structures, negotiate participation norms, and influence the pace and format of interaction, teachers enabled communicative situations to be shaped around students' relational and affective needs. This approach aligned with research stressing the importance of communicative partner relationships, teacher behaviors, task design, and perceived safety for situational WTC (Zhang et al., 2018. Teachers observed that students increasingly managed group dynamics independently and engaged more willingly in collaborative communicative tasks when interactional conditions were co-constructed rather than imposed. These results also align with research indicating the potential of restorative practices to strengthen relationships, increase student participation, and foster a more inclusive classroom climate (Lodi et al., 2021).

These results mirror participants' experience with engaging in collaborative inquiry within a distributed authority structure through negotiated means of participation. The teachers were given the authority to make critical choices based on the conditions of their respective work situations, prior knowledge, interests, strengths and limitations which facilitated meaningful participation despite being situated in complex, uncertain, and dynamic situations, which are often cited as limiting factors to teachers' uptake of empirical knowledge (Eraut, 1985; Francisco, Seiser & Almqvist, 2024; Schön, 1983; Sato and Loewen, 2022)

Participants consistently noted that the emergent, collaboratively driven inquiry process supported a transformative understanding of relational practices and of how jointly constructed communicative structures can shape contextual conditions for students' willingness to communicate. Importantly, this development did not rely on extensive time investment in acquiring externally produced knowledge, which participants identified as a central strength of the approach. Instead, professional learning emerged through sustained engagement with everyday practice, collective reflection, and iterative experimentation.

These findings align with research on collegial learning and practice-situated professional development, which emphasises professional agency, local relevance, and the co-construction of knowledge in and through practice rather than through transmissive models of professional development (Rönnerman, 2012; Löfström & Areskoug, 2020). From this perspective, professional knowledge is understood as situated and relational, developed through iterative cycles of reflection, action, and collective sense-making (Rönnerman & Salo, 2017; Edwards-Groves et al., 2021).

In this light, the present findings also speak to recent critiques of centrally governed, standards-based professional development initiatives in Sweden, which risk prioritising predetermined content and compliance over context-sensitive, practice-situated learning (Francisco, Forssten Seiser & Olin Almqvist, 2024). The results of this study suggest that professional learning models that adopt a participatory design inquiry informed by restorative pedagogy approach as means to locally meaningful problem-solving may offer a more feasible and responsive alternative for supporting teachers' development of relational and communicative practices.

The unexpected enthusiasm for participation in this project on the part of participating teachers together with the observed responses of students to decentering authority in both the inquiry process and in emergent instructional design inspired the name Dare to Share for this study and for the relational model developed by the participants. While, at first participants experienced hesitance to trust that the decision to share authority would lead to acceptable outcomes, on all levels, in the end it was considered the most impactful asset of this approach.

Conclusions

The aim of this study was to investigate how EFL teachers experience participation in a participatory design process informed by restorative relational perspectives, and how such participation shapes professional understanding and teaching practices related to students' willingness to communicate. The findings indicate that participants experienced the process as a meaningful, practice-situated form of professional learning that supported both the development of relational teaching practices and teachers' professional learning in situ.

A central conclusion of the study is that the participatory design process, informed by restorative pedagogy, enabled teachers to integrate theoretical understandings of willingness to communicate into their everyday teaching practice without relying on extensive engagement with externally produced knowledge. Instead, professional learning emerged through collaborative inquiry, reflection, and experimentation grounded in participants' own classroom contexts. This stands in contrast to participants' prior experiences of professional development, which were often described as compulsory, performative, or disconnected from practice.

Participants identified their experiences with distributed authority, negotiated participation, and an explicit focus on relational conditions as the critical factor resulting in a more valuable professional learning experience and more developed, responsive approaches to classroom interaction. By trusting students with greater influence over communicative situations and participation norms, teachers developed interactional practices that emphasised student agency, affective safety, and shared responsibility for communication. These relational and interactional shifts were experienced as an asset in supporting students' willingness to communicate in EFL classrooms, reinforcing the understanding of WTC as a fundamentally relational pedagogical concern.

In a broader perspective, the findings contribute to ongoing discussions about how the mandate for teaching grounded in scientific knowledge and proven experience can be realised in practice. The study suggests that participatory, practice-situated professional learning models may offer a viable way of bridging the research–practice gap by enabling teachers to develop context-sensitive, evidence-informed practices through collaborative inquiry rather than through transmissive professional development formats. From a didactic standpoint, the results emphasize the importance of relational and interactional aspects of teaching for communicative language learning.

While the study was conducted on a small scale, its findings point to the potential value of further research into participatory and restorative approaches to professional learning in language education. Future studies could explore how such approaches function across different school contexts, subject areas, and student populations, as well as how they might be supported structurally within existing educational systems. Taken together, the findings suggest that creating appropriate scaffolding for relational, participatory, and practice-based professional inquiry may be a key component in supporting both teachers' professional development and students' communicative engagement in EFL classrooms.

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Appendix

Appendix 1

Consent form



UPPSALA
UNIVERSITET

Department of Education

Hi,

You have been invited to take part in a research project that explores how participating in a Participatory Design process, guided by Restorative Practices, may influence how a group of language teachers understand their students' willingness to communicate in English and how they design their lessons. It will do so by analysing the observations, discussions, thoughts and feelings of the participants as they participate in the design process. The guiding principle of participatory design we are investigating involves participant cooperation at all levels of the study. You will hence co-create this research with us. This does however mean that you will not be able to remain anonymous.

This (potentially) new way of approaching lesson design might bring with it some uncertainty, as all new things tend to do. You will however never be forced to do anything you are uncomfortable with but introduce the restorative practices and participatory design to a degree that you are comfortable with.

The process, which will go on for no more than three months from the opening meeting, will consider all of the ethical guidelines that are to be held in research. You will therefore: be informed about the research before you agree to participate, be able to withdraw from the process at any time, have any data collected handled with utmost care and get ongoing information about how this data will be used.

I have been informed about what my participation will entail □

…….hereby consent to participate in this research process

If you have any questions, please do not hesitate to reach out to either at:

Appendix 2

Participant: Date:

Pre-Process Reflective Journal Entry

Purpose

Before starting the collaborative design process, this entry is meant to capture your current experience with students' willingness to communicate in English in the classroom. There are no right or wrong answers, just answer each question thoughtfully and focus on what feels true for you. Feel free to write in either Swedish or English.

Part 1 To be answered before our first meeting

1. In what ways do you think using English to communicate in the classroom is important for students' language development?

2. In your experience are there certain kinds of activities or situations in which your students are less willing to use English to communicate?

3a. Are there certain kinds of lessons, activities, situations or assignments you avoid doing with your students due to their hesitance to communicate in English? If so, what kinds?

3b. In what ways do you think those activities would benefit your students' language development?

To what extent do you agree with the following statements?

4. The students I have right now are very willing to communicate in English in my classes. (choose one)
1 = strongly disagree, 2 = disagree, 3 = partially agree, 4 = agree, 5 = strongly agree

Would you like to expand your answer? (optional)

5. I feel confident in my ability to support students who are hesitant to communicate in English (choose one)
1 = strongly disagree, 2 = disagree, 3 = partially agree, 4 = agree, 5 = strongly agree

Would you like to expand your answer? (optional)

6. I have strategies that work well to support students who aren't willing to communicate in English. (choose one)
1 = strongly disagree, 2 = disagree, 3 = partially agree, 4 = agree, 5 = strongly agree

Would you like to expand your answer? (optional)

7. Students' hesitance to communicate in English often hinders lessons/activities/assignments I plan (choose one)
1 = strongly disagree, 2 = disagree, 3 = partially agree, 4 = agree, 5 = strongly agree

Would you like to expand your answer? (optional)

This part of the initial journal entry is meant to capture your thoughts, expectations and feelings about participating in the study.

Part 2 To be answered soon after our first meeting

1. What are your initial thoughts on participating in a collegial learning process involving co-designing, piloting and analysing new kinds of lessons and activities together with other language teachers?

2. Which parts (if any) do you feel might be difficult or uncomfortable for you?

3. How would you describe your relationship to the other participants at this point in time?

4. What do you hope to get out of the time you will invest into this study?

Appendix 3

Participant: Date:

Reflective Journal Template

Purpose

These journal entries are a space for you to reflect on your experiences as you design and carry out classroom activities connected to this project. The aim is to capture your thinking, observations, and feelings in the moment, so there is no need to produce any kind of polished writing. Please complete one entry after each relevant lesson with your students — ideally within 24 hours of the event. Feel free to write in either Swedish or English.

Lesson/activity brief description:

Learning goals for the teacher and/or students this lesson:

Materials used:

Your role:

- Did the lesson/activity go as planned? If not, what was different?
- Were the goals met? Why or why not?
- Were the goals you set for yourself challenging? In what way?
- What did you find noteworthy about the lesson?
- Did anything surprise you or challenge your expectations?
- Are there any changes or adjustments you think would make the lesson/activity better?
- Is there anything you would like to bring up with the design team?